

captive global capability centres (GCCs) built by giants such as Microsoft, Google, Goldman Sachs and Amazon in the past two decades with tens of thousands of employees.

They are 'nano' or even 'micro' GCCs—with staff from a few dozen to a few hundred—set up by mid-market enterprises such as DAMAC that see great value in doing so in India: a cost-smart approach with rapid activation and tight control over core work.

GCC IN A BOX

"This marks a new phase in the evolution of GCC models. Enterprises are no longer starting with scale. They are starting with a strategy," says Monica Pirgal, CEO of Bhartiya Converge. "New approaches like GCC-in-a-Box or GCC-as-a-Service enable companies to establish focused, high-skill centres around artificial intelligence (AI), product engineering and cybersecurity."

Pirgal has held leadership roles at Lowe's India and Goldman Sachs India. In 2025, she joined Bhartiya Converge, a platform that helps companies set up GCCs.

Small GCCs are typically being set up by companies with global revenue of up to \$2 billion, says a report by the National Association of Software and Service Companies (NASSCOM) and Zinnov.

For them, India offers a 30–50% cost advantage versus comparable talent in the US or Europe.

"About 60% of the demand last year was for mid-market GCCs. The GCC model is mature and here to stay. Besides, AI is creating a big push for GCC build-outs," says Vikram Ahuja, Co-founder and CEO of ANSR, a consultancy that has helped set up more than 200 GCCs.

BENEFITS OF NANO GCCs

Reasonable set-up and operating costs

Shared services

Cost-efficient automation and engineering development

India delivers 30-50% costs savings

Low talent acquisition and retention costs

Easier to start in Tier II cities as headcount requirements are not huge

Access to flexible workforce model, enabling scale-up or scale-down without heavy fixed costs

The work these centres handle is very different from the back-office stereotype. Ahuja estimates that 60–70% of new GCC activity is in technology—AI, product engineering and software—while the remaining 30% spans marketing, design, customer success, IT and procurement.

That is why companies such as San Francisco-based Meltwater, a global media, social and consumer intelligence firm, are coming to India. In 2025, Meltwater started a 60-people GCC in Hyderabad to do research and development (R&D) work, with plans to grow to 150 engineers by the end of 2026.

The Hyderabad GCC is poised to become the company's emerging AI hub. Among the key innovations developed by the India team are MIRA (Meltwater's AI team-mate), which uses generative AI to deliver instant insights through a conversational interface, simplifying complex workflows such as brand monitoring and competitive intelligence to meet the demands of 27,000 customers worldwide.

The Hyderabad team has also built multilingual named-entity recognition (NER) models that recognise entities within text. The NER models analyse content in more than 200 languages and turn raw data into decision-ready intelligence. "It's not only about cost arbitrage. The vision is to have a full-scale R&D operation that does product development and product engineering," says Dhruv Gupta, senior director of engineering and General Manager at Meltwater India.

Pirgal of Bhartiya Converge says: "The real advantage for small GCCs comes from achieving the right balance between cost, quality and value. While Tier II